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Will California ban ultra-processed foods in school meals? - The Legislature is considering phasing out chemical additives in school meals linked to health problems. Opponents say the definitions are so broad that it could ban items like tomato sauce and olive oil.

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During the school year, kids attending schools in the Tahoe region are served cafeteria meals of ground turkey tacos, chicken or tofu bowls with brown rice, a salad bar filled with locally grown produce and other healthy items.

About 80% of breakfasts and lunches served at Tahoe-Truckee Unified School District are made from scratch without food additives such as dyes and preservatives, and nutrition workers have worked to eliminate prepackaged foods and serve minimally processed meals.

"The health of your entree is your ingredients, so we control those ingredients by cooking or making our own," said Kat Soltanmorad, food and nutrition services director with the district.

Tahoe-Truckee Unified is part of a small but growing group of school districts in California trying to make the billion meals served in public K-12 schools every year healthier and less processed. The schools have relied on nearly $15 billion in state and federal funding over the past few years to begin making some of these changes.

Now lawmakers have set their sights on mandating improvements in school meals. A measure introduced by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat from Encino, aims to start phasing out some ultra-processed food at schools by 2028 and remove them by 2035. The bill targets foods with chemical additives, such as stabilizers, coloring and flavoring agents.

The bill doesn't list specific foods or additives that would be banned. Instead, it tasks the state's environmental health agency with identifying "particularly harmful" ingredients by next July. But there's controversy brewing between the bill's supporters and the agriculture and food manufacturing industries that worry safe products could be targeted.

For example, pizza — a favorite among students — often contains many ingredients like dough conditioners and stabilizers that manufacturers say are needed to produce the foods and keep them shelf-stable. Health experts say some are linked to cancer and other health harms.

The bipartisan measure passed the Assembly in a 65-1 vote, with 13 members not voting, and is now being considered by the Senate. It comes on the heels of a January executive order from Gov. Gavin Newsom directing the state health department to recommend how to limit harm from ultra-processed foods. The proposal also coincides with U.S. Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s "Make America Healthy Again" campaign, which prioritizes chronic disease, including obesity and diabetes.

"There is a growing national awareness, particularly among parents, about how deeply what we feed our kids impacts their physical and mental health," Gabriel said. "Even though Republicans and Democrats can't agree on much, one of the things they can agree on is this common sense notion that we should be protecting our kids."

James Gallagher, Republican Assembly leader and co-author of the bill, said he used to be skeptical about state efforts to regulate additives like food dyes, but as he reviewed the evidence, he became convinced that kids should not consume them.

"Our kids should be eating better," said Gallagher, a sixth-generation rice farmer from Chico. "What we all agree on really is let's get out the most harmful ingredients that might be present in foods that are going into kids lunches."

A coalition of grocers, farmers, food and beverage manufacturers, and business groups has risen in fierce opposition to the measure. They say that creating a system that designates most groceries as ultra-processed will give consumers the false impression that their food is unsafe.

More than 80% of products sold in grocery stores would be considered ultra-processed under the state definition, said Dennis Albiani, president of lobbying firm Capitol Advocates representing the coalition.

"The definitions are so broad and so vague that many both healthy and determined healthy products are going to be pulled in and labeled as ultra-processed, which in the lexicon of America means dangerous and unhealthy," Albiani said.

For example, manufacturers inject small amounts of nitrous oxide into the top of olive oil bottles to prevent the oil from oxidizing, he said. Canned goods like tomatoes and other vegetables often contain citric acid and other preservatives. Vegan and vegetarian meat supplements, which are touted as being healthy and environmentally friendly, also rely on thickeners, flavors and binders. Under the state's proposed legislation, all of these added ingredients could classify those foods as ultra-processed, Albiani said.

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